

Contact sheet

Want to get these players? We've put up the contacts for these companies at www.thinkdigit.com/d/dvdcontacts



Record and preview in 3D

Hammacher Schlemmer have started selling a 3D camcorder, capable of recording 3D video at 640 x 480 pixel resolutions following which users can see the 3D content without wearing 3D glasses

ping at 320kbps and a UI that allows tweaking of parameters such as hue, contrast, sharpness etc. A worthy buy for a throw away price of Rs. 1,699.

Blu-ray Players

Blu-ray players are a different league of HD entertainment. The kind of crystal clear pixel for pixel reproduction that this format offers has to be truly experienced to be believed. Blu-ray players have a native output resolution of 1080p. Besides stunning visual performance, BD players come with BD Live - a content service that allows your player to download value added features based on the title you're playing. Now, although we have been featuring BD players in Bazaar from time to time, this is the first time they've been pitted against each other in an all out comparison test.

Performance

When it comes to strictly Video performance or playback quality there is really a very minute discernible difference between the players. In fact to an untrained eye viewing on a low end LCD screen the difference will not be noticeable at all. Having said that, we used one of the better displays we had for this one and used a variety of scenes to be exactly sure of quality with respect to colour depth, motion blurring, film grain, and other parameters. The performance of BD as well as DVD was considered. Not surprisingly, Blu-ray players were not backward compat-

HOW WE TESTED

For this test a focused attempt was made to completely rid the process from subjectivity and reviewer's bias. Apart from quality, each and every feature, however small, was tested for efficiency and given a score. Manufacturers often push the envelope of technology to come out with features that end up becoming points on the specs sheet and in reality don't work as intended. Weights were given to quality of video both on the player and via USB. Similarly codec/format support was an important consideration. We hooked up players to the Samsung 32 inch LED, a TV that scored pretty high on our LCD TV test last month. The various motion smoothing options such as motion plus and sharpness enhancement were turned off.

DVD Quality: Obviously, this component was given the maximum weightage on our value calculator for DVD players. We used an average score from three of our favourite movies this time - *Good Will Hunting*, *Crash* and *Reservoir Dogs*. In *Good Will Hunting* we observed the colour depth of city life in general while playing the "Crusin for a bruising" scene. For *Crash* the

climactic scene titled "A Really Good Cloak" was used to get an idea of the sharpness and motion sensitivity. The Title Walk scene in *Reservoir Dogs* gives an idea of how players handle film grain.

Blu-ray Quality: This test was the most fun, because we really couldn't get tired of the movies we chose - *Iron Man* and *Dark Knight*. An average score of three scenes was calculated.

USB quality and format support: Players do promise DivX playback via USB but do they do a good job of upscaling? That's what we rated the players on. Besides DivX, if a player supported a greater range of file formats it got a higher score.

Product Design and Appearance: Design is not just about looks. Players which had buttons that are hard to reach or USB ports that are on the side or worse, exclusively at the back were given a lower score. A certain percentage was given to looks in terms of how it would look as part of a typical home set up. You wouldn't want something that's too jarring in this respect.

Connectivity: Being able to

connect your TV to your player and sound system easily is what we were looking for. Composite, Component, 5.1 channel audio ports and HDMI ports were the most looked for. Having HDMI connectivity is a great as it eliminates the use of RCA and composite cables or component connectivity as both audio and video are passed through one cable. All the DVD players we tested came with USB ports and most of them also came with memory card support. This is a big advantage as you can watch movie straight off your pen drive or browse pictures off a memory card.

Miscellaneous parameters: The thumb rule is "The more features the better", but with a caveat - they should work as promised. We also placed a good amount of weightage on ease of use. The ease of use comprised of the menu system interface, the ease of use of the remote, and the UI used to browse content from USB. We found that UIs that had a mixture of folder structure and sorting by content type were the easiest to use. We tested audio playback using 320 kbps MP3 tracks to evaluate how the players handled highs, mids and lows.

ible with VCD - clearly a dying format, which for obvious reasons we did not include in the test criteria even for pure DVD players.

When we were testing the players we actually found that there are two distinct



Philips BDP 7500

Buying Reckoner

You want	Go for
The best value for money DVD player that has a decent performance + features mix, and doesn't burn a hole in your pocket.	Soyer 338MC
A DVD player that gives the best performance and feature set in this category	Philips DVP 3588
A DVD player which is affordable and offers great video performance thanks to an HDMI out	Onida HDR-5522 (Atom)
The best value for money Blu-ray player that offers excellent video performance and an unusually large amount of features such as internet content.	Sony S-370
The best performing Blu-ray player that money can buy.	Philips BDP 7500